

THE 90% CODE

REWRITING POWER FOR THE AI ERA

A FIELD GUIDE



We are living through a rupture, *not a transition.*

Climate destabilization. Democracy at its lowest measured levels in decades. Displacement and poverty affecting billions. Wealth concentration at levels not seen since the Gilded Age. Technology reshaping work, knowledge, and daily life faster than our institutions can respond.

We are told these are separate crises — some economic, some political, some technological. The newest version: it is all because of AI. None of these framings reach the depth of what is breaking.

The operating system that governs how decisions are made, who holds authority, and who captures value is failing — not because leaders are incompetent, but because it was designed for a simpler world. Concentrated authority cannot govern distributed complexity. Extraction economics eventually exhaust what they extract. Hierarchies optimized for control become brittle under stress.

This is the deeper rupture: the Hero Model — where the few decide, and the many defer; where authority concentrates at the top — has hit its structural limits. The human brain can hold only a handful of variables in working memory at once. Modern systems involve thousands of variables interacting in real time across global networks. No individual mind can hold the whole. Heroic concentration creates the appearance of control precisely where control has become *mathematically impossible*.

*When linear governance meets exponential systems,
power does not distribute. It concentrates, by design.*

AI makes this rupture *irreversible* — toward concentration or toward distribution, but not toward the world we had. Every prior disruption — agricultural, industrial, digital — left decades for institutions, workers, and communities to adapt. The rate at which new opportunity can be created is no longer keeping pace with the rate at which existing arrangements are dissolving. And AI's critical infrastructure — compute, data, model ownership, deployment channels — is consolidating rapidly into a few corporate and state actors. Collective knowledge becoming private property, faster than at any moment in history.

*The infrastructure that will carry the next economy
is being enclosed before most people know it exists.*

THE NUMBERS



What concentration looks like —
value extracted upward, weight carried below.

1.6%

of adults now control nearly half of global wealth:
\$226 trillion of \$454 trillion total.

399:1

CEO-to-worker pay ratio, up from 30:1 in 1979.
Typical worker productivity is up 80% since then.
Typical worker pay, up just 15%.

~90%

of the enterprise LLM market is controlled by
three companies: Anthropic, OpenAI, and Google.

7%

of the world's population now lives under a *full*
liberal democracy, the lowest share in over fifty
years.

Sources: Credit Suisse Global Wealth Report, 2023. Economic Policy Institute, productivity-pay gap data 2021. Menlo Ventures, State of Generative AI in the Enterprise: 2025 Report. V-Dem Institute, Democracy Report 2026.

The numbers confirm what most people already feel. The top 10 percent today own more than the bottom 90 percent combined. Fewer than 10 percent of workers hold equity in the companies they help build. Most people have no meaningful stake in the systems that shape their lives.

The 90 percent is the *essential majority*, defined not by income but by proximity to power. What unites them is that their capacity to contribute exceeds the structures available to capture it.

Nobel laureate economist Joseph Stiglitz argues that an economic system which does not deliver for the vast majority of its citizens is a *failed economy*. By this measure, we are living inside a failed economy — one that functions as designed: concentrate ownership, centralize decision rights, socialize risk downward, privatize returns upward.

This is not a fight over who holds power. It is a question of how power moves.

The question this book answers:

What operating system can actually govern exponential complexity, total interdependence, and existential velocity?

The answer is not better heroes. It is the 90 percent learning to lead together *instead of waiting to be led*.

This is what the moment calls for: not individual brilliance, not heroic insight, but *collective intelligence* — the capacity of a group to perceive, process, and respond to complexity in ways no individual member could achieve alone.

As AI commoditizes individual expertise, what gives an organization, or a society, its edge is shifting from the sharpness of any one person to the structures through which people think, decide, and build collectively. The choice is stark: concentrate power further, or distribute it. *The 90% Code is a framework for distribution.*

"The purpose of a system is what it does."

— Stafford Beer

Not what it's supposed to do. Not what the org chart says it does. What it actually produces. If your organization produces burnout, that's its purpose — regardless of the mission statement. If your policy produces inequality, that's its purpose — regardless of the stated intent.

THE FRAMEWORK

The 90% Code is the operating system collective intelligence runs on. The framework has two parts. One is what each person carries inside themselves — the capacities that make distributed intelligence possible at the level of any individual mind. The other is what surrounds them — the infrastructure that lets those capacities operate beyond any single organization.

Both are needed.

Without the inner work, structures designed for distributed intelligence get filled by people still operating from the old reflexes. Without the structures, the inner work stays trapped inside systems built to extract from it.

The 90% Code

five capacities · three infrastructures · one operating system

COLLECTIVE INTELLIGENCE

Groups thinking, deciding, and acting with a coherence that exceeds any individual contribution — what emerges when the five capacities and three infrastructures align.

the stakes

Hero vs collective

Techno-feudalism vs distributed abundance

Survival vs self-actualization



FIVE COLLECTIVE CAPACITIES

each strengthens the others



Inner Alignment

the root

The capacity to align thought, feeling, and action so you operate from awareness rather than autopilot.

Meta-awareness · Self-authorship · Conscious body and mind · Emotion as information

the four below grow from inner alignment



Relational Intelligence

The capacity to build authentic connection so trust becomes the infrastructure that holds distributed systems together.

From empathy to compassion

Relationship before results

Building trust as a leader

The science of repair



Systems Stewardship

The capacity to see interconnections, how decisions ripple into consequences, and who bears the impact.

Seven generations thinking

Policy intersectionality

The scale of a leader's impact

Finding the right leverage points



Ethical Foresight

The capacity to design for consequences you will not personally experience.

Beyond the quarterly horizon

Ethics 2.0

The ethics-vs-scale paradox

Intergenerational stewardship



Regenerative Action

The capacity to build systems that restore rather than deplete.

From extraction to regeneration

Regenerative economics

Designing closed loops

Measuring what matters



THREE INFRASTRUCTURAL SHIFTS

capacities can't hold without them



Economic

· who owns, who captures value

The architecture that distributes value to those who create it.

Why labour always loses ($r > g$) · The one-sixth principle · Economic democracy · Cooperatives & distributed ownership



Democratic

· who decides, who has voice

The architecture that distributes authority to those affected by decisions.

Why representative democracy fails · Citizens' assemblies · Participatory budgeting · Digital deliberation



Trust in the age of AI

· who governs the intelligence

The architecture that makes AI accountable to those it affects.

Governance & trust vacuum · The builders' trap · The AI Assessment Framework · The centaur future

Structure without capacity collapses. Capacity without structure dissipates. The 90% Code requires both.

REFUSING THE SILO

Every serious attempt to redesign power has been partial. Management books optimize organizations. Policy books fix institutions. Indigenous traditions hold millennia of wisdom on stewardship. Cooperative economics shows how value can be distributed rather than captured. Systems research shows mathematically why distributed structures outperform centralized ones in complexity. *Each field is sharp. Each is alone.* This book refuses the silo — because the answer to concentrated power was never going to come from a single discipline.

Systems design, done honestly, is cross-sectoral by necessity. It holds research and lived experience in the same hand. It draws on what elders knew and what peer-reviewed studies now confirm — what has been proven in a controlled setting, and what has been proven in a village, a nursing team, a cooperative, a city. *Management theory meets ancient intelligence. Controlled studies meet lived evidence.*

A triangulated, transdisciplinary synthesis — research across many fields, tested against systems already working in the world, made into tools you can use. Where the three meet is the framework.



FROM SYMPTOM TO SYSTEM

Can the system you are inside hold the weight of what is coming?

You are looking at a system (a team, a company, a board, an AI deployment, a policy you are designing) and you want to know whether it can hold the weight of what is coming. Whether it can adapt to accelerating AI, geopolitical instability, climate disruption, the erosion of institutions you once relied on. Whether the people inside it can act collectively when the situation demands more than any one of them can deliver. Whether it is *built to last*, or only to react.

Right now, most cannot.

70%

of public-sector digital transformations fail to reach their goals
— despite governments spending over \$800 billion a year on technology.

UNDP, State of Government Digital Transformation, 2026

95%

of enterprise generative AI pilots fail to deliver measurable revenue impact.

MIT, State of AI in Business, 2025

70%

of large-scale organizational transformations fail to achieve their stated objectives.

McKinsey, replicated across two decades

The World Bank's *Improving Public Sector Performance* (2018) finds that lasting improvement turns less on technology than on *political leadership, incentives, and institutional capacity*.

When this happens, leaders reach for one of two explanations. We chose the wrong technology, and the response is to upgrade the stack, change the vendor, run another pilot. We have the wrong people, and the response is to restructure, lay off, hire in. *Both responses miss what is actually failing.*

It is not a technology problem. It is not a people problem.

It is a systems problem.

THE 90% CODE SYSTEM DIAGNOSTIC

The canvas maps your system across all eight elements: the five capacities and three infrastructural shifts. It surfaces where the system is strong, where it is stuck, and what to work on first. It moves you from *we need to do something* to *we know what to do first*. It is a structural diagnostic, designed to make visible the gap between what people in the system can do and what the system itself allows.

— The canvas follows.

THE 90% CODE SYSTEM DIAGNOSTIC

Score each dimension 1–5
1 Absent · 2 Emerging · 3 Developing · 4 Established · 5 Leading

The system I am diagnosing: _____

FIVE CAPACITIES

What people develop. Each strengthens the others.

1. Inner Alignment

Am I operating from awareness or autopilot?

1 2 3 4 5

2. Relational Intelligence

Where is trust missing or broken?

1 2 3 4 5

3. Systems Stewardship

What am I not seeing?

1 2 3 4 5

4. Ethical Foresight

Who is affected but has no voice?

1 2 3 4 5

5. Regenerative Action

Am I extracting or restoring?

1 2 3 4 5

THREE INFRASTRUCTURES

What structures enable. Capacities without infrastructure remain personal development.

1. Economic Infrastructure

Who owns? Who captures value?

1 2 3 4 5

2. Democratic Infrastructure

Who decides? Who has voice?

1 2 3 4 5

3. Trust Infrastructure

Who governs the intelligence? (See Appendix B)

1 2 3 4 5

v diagnose the system v

Read Your Profile

Barrier Point
Lowest score =

where the system is stuck

Interlock Check
Are your 3 infra scores within 1 pt? =

Gap >= 2 = interlock failure

Capacity-Infra Gap
Avg capacities vs. avg infra =

Gap > 1.5 = misalignment

v target your barrier point v

30-Day Experiment

Targeting
Which barrier point?

Action
What will I change?

Signal
How will I know?

v from action to emergence v

Collective Intelligence: Your Hypothesis

If this works, I expect to see:

CI is emerging when:

Reassess on:

Sit with the questions before you score.

Bring each question to your own present moment. Not the system in general, the one you are inside. The questions are the diagnostic. The scores come later.

FIVE COLLECTIVE CAPACITIES

what people develop

INNER ALIGNMENT	<i>Am I reacting from autopilot rather than responding from awareness?</i>
RELATIONAL INTELLIGENCE	<i>Where is communication breaking down with someone who matters to me?</i>
SYSTEMS STEWARDSHIP	<i>Am I trying to control a system rather than understand it?</i>
ETHICAL FORESIGHT	<i>What decision am I currently facing that affects people who have no voice in it?</i>
REGENERATIVE ACTION	<i>Am I extracting from a system (people, resources, relationships) without replenishing?</i>

THREE INFRASTRUCTURAL SHIFTS

what structures enable

ECONOMIC	<i>Am I creating value without owning a share of what it produces?</i>
DEMOCRATIC	<i>Am I subject to decisions I had no voice in shaping?</i>
TRUST	<i>Which AI system shapes decisions about me that I cannot hold accountable?</i>

WHAT THE CANVAS REVEALS

Barrier Point — your lowest score across all eight elements. The single weakest dimension that caps everything else.

Interlock Check — whether your three infrastructural shifts hold together. When one lags, it undermines the other two.

Capacity-Infrastructure Gap — whether the system is moving together. When capacities outgrow structures, or structures outpace people.

THIS IS THE ENTRY POINT, NOT THE FULL TOOL

What you have here — the canvas, its eight core questions, and the diagnostic logic. Enough to begin seeing your system clearly.

What the book builds in you — the practice. The canvas gives you the questions. The book builds the muscle behind them through the full learning cycle: **concept, experience, reflection, application**. Field notes from systems already operating at scale. Reflections that build the lens before you use it. A complete scoring rubric with behavioural anchors at every level. So the framework becomes how you see, not what you reference.

The 90% Code — October 2026.

THE BLACK BOX

You've already been judged by systems you will never see.

If you have applied for a job in the last five years, an algorithm likely screened your résumé before a human saw it. If you have applied for a loan, a credit model scored you. If you have scrolled social media, recommendation engines decided what you would find interesting, alarming, or enraging.

These are not distant technologies but *the infrastructure of daily life*. What they share is opacity.

*We are being governed by systems we cannot see,
built by people we did not choose, optimizing for goals we did not set.*

That is not a technology problem. It is a governance failure. And it is already here.

THE MISSING PILLAR

Every tool we have built has eventually been governed by infrastructure stronger than itself.

AI is a tool, though unlike any tool we have built before. It generates, decides, and increasingly acts on its own. We built Economic Infrastructure to govern the flow of capital. We built Democratic Infrastructure to govern the flow of authority. Both are imperfect. Both are contested. *But they exist.*

AI sits outside both, because it is the first intelligent technology we have built, and intelligence does not fit either category. It can heal, and it can harm. It can democratize knowledge, and it can concentrate power. Same technology, opposite outcomes. The space between this technology and the people it shapes is wider than any infrastructure we currently have.

Call that space the *trust gap*.

Trust Infrastructure is what closes it — the architecture that lets the 90 percent verify what AI is doing, hold the people building it accountable, and step in when the system fails the people it was supposed to serve.

WHAT GETS MEASURED

What gets measured — *and what doesn't.*

Existing frameworks (NIST AI RMF, the EU AI Act, ISO 42001) do important work. They assess AI systems for technical soundness, governance, risk, and compliance.

But few systematically ask the questions that matter most to the people on the receiving end:

- *Whether the system depletes or develops human capacity.*
- *Whether power flows toward or away from the communities it serves.*
- *Whether the harm it causes can be reversed, or only explained.*

*The gap between what matters and what gets measured
is not accidental. It is structural.*

THE AI ASSESSMENT FRAMEWORK

One instrument of Trust Infrastructure: a way to ask, of any AI system, whether it is *trustworthy to the people it affects*. It works across five dimensions — Epistemic Integrity, Capacity Orientation, Power Architecture, Contextual Intelligence, and Accountability Architecture — each assessed through two lenses: what the builder designs into the system, and what the adopter experiences in practice.

The diagnostic signal is the *Alignment Gap* — where the two diverge. When the builder's claim and the adopter's reality diverge by two or more levels on any dimension, that gap is the trust risk. The output is not a score. It is a profile that makes misalignment visible — and a shared language for the conversation governance has been missing.

— *The framework follows.*

THE 90% CODE AI ASSESSMENT FRAMEWORK

Five dimensions, fifteen criteria for assessing whether AI systems are trustworthy to the people they affect

Builder Lens

What did we design into the system?

Dimension • Shared Criteria

Adopter Lens

In practice, what do we see?

1

Does it signal uncertainty, resist agreement pressure, and show its reasoning?

Epistemic Integrity

UNCERTAINTY SIGNALLING
SYCOPHANCY RESISTANCE
REASONING TRANSPARENCY

Can our people spot when it's guessing, catch sycophancy, and verify outputs?

2

Does it build human capability — or create dependency?

Capacity Orientation

AUGMENTATION DESIGN
SKILL PRESERVATION
CAPABILITY INVESTMENT

Are our people growing more capable — and do efficiency gains go back into developing them?

3

Do users own their data, share the value, and govern the system?

Power Architecture

DATA SOVEREIGNTY
VALUE DISTRIBUTION
VOICE & AUTHORITY

Who captures the value — and do workers and communities have real say?

4

Does it work equitably, respect diverse knowledge, and reach the excluded?

Contextual Intelligence

INCLUSIVE DESIGN
KNOWLEDGE PLURALISM
ACCESSIBLE DESIGN

Does it work for our whole community — are local and Indigenous ways of knowing respected?

5

Can decisions be traced, harm reversed, and does it leave more than it consumes?

Accountability Architecture

AUDIT ACCESS
REMEDY BY DESIGN
INTERGENERATIONAL STEWARDSHIP

Do affected people have real authority — not just feedback — and what does it leave behind?

☐ The Alignment Gap — the diagnostic signal

When Builder and Adopter scores diverge by two or more levels, that gap is the trust risk. The output is not a score. It is a profile that makes misalignment visible.

1 ABSENT • 2 EMERGING • 3 DEVELOPING • 4 ESTABLISHED • 5 LEADING
Each criterion scored independently. Scores of 4+ require documented evidence — not assertions.

Scoring protocol, full rubrics, and the practitioner canvas ☐ Appendix B

This is a living framework. The current version ☐ the90code.com

TRY IT

Run the lens on a system *you already use.*

Pick one AI system you rely on — the tool at work, the model you prompt daily, the algorithm deciding what reaches you. Hold it against the five dimensions, twice.

THE BUILDER LENS *what was designed in?*

Does it flag its own uncertainty, or state wrong answers with full confidence? Does it push back, or just agree with you? Does it carry the biases of its training data into your context?

THE ADOPTER LENS *what do you actually experience?*

Do you catch it when it's guessing, or take the output on faith? Are your people growing more capable — or more dependent? Who captures the value it produces, and who carries the risk when it fails?

The dimension where the two answers diverge most — that is where your trust is most at risk. That gap is the finding.

THIS IS THE ENTRY POINT, NOT THE FULL TOOL

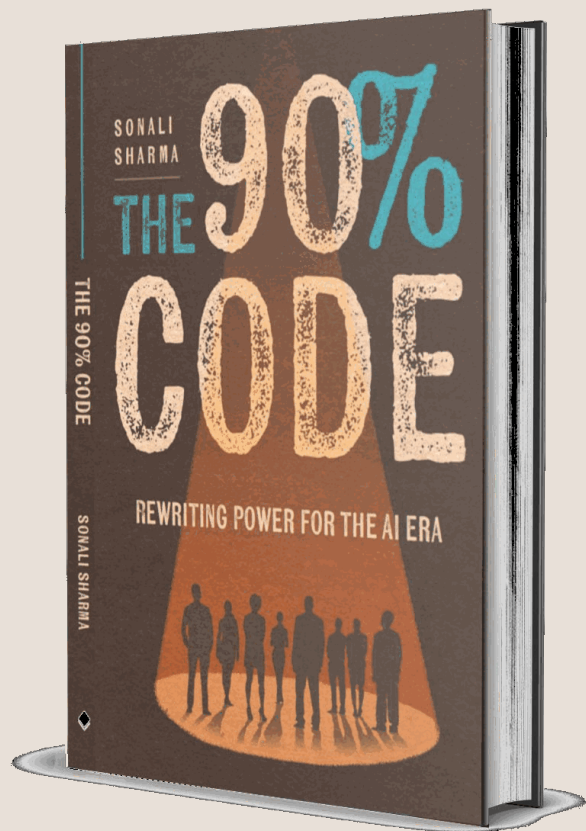
What you have here — enough to run the lens on one system and see where the gap opens.

What the book builds in you — the full practice. Fifteen criteria across the five dimensions, each assessed through both lenses and scored on a five-point maturity scale. The evidence standard that separates a claim from a capability. Case studies showing how the Alignment Gap reveals where governance is missing — and what to do once you have found it.

The 90% Code — October 2026.

Trust Infrastructure

is the architecture that lets the 90 percent
verify what AI is doing,
hold the people building it accountable,
and step in when the system fails
the people it was supposed to serve.



THE 90% CODE

Be the first
to read it.

The 90% Code launches October 2026. Join the launch list and I'll send you the Prelude and Chapter 1 as a thank-you, plus launch updates and the canvases as they're released free.

JOIN THE LAUNCH LIST

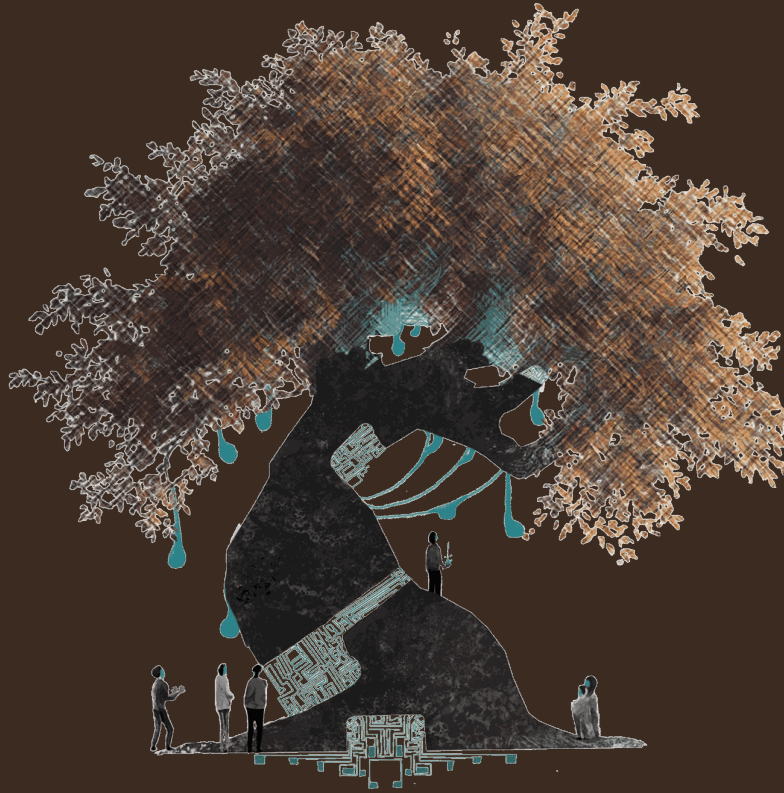
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MEET THE AUTHOR

Sonali Sharma

Sonali Sharma writes from inside the 90 percent this book is for. A BIPOC immigrant, she has spent two decades building across continents and sectors — founding a closed-loop impact business with Indigenous artisans in South India, leading enterprise and leadership development across Asia, and directing public-sector technology innovation strategy in Canada. Today, she mentors tech startups, speaks on AI governance, and is building **ANAI**, an AI-powered preventive wellness platform. She lives in Vancouver with her family.

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Five capacities that develop humans. Three infrastructures that distribute the power. Collective intelligence is what emerges when both are genuinely in place.

The 90% Code is being written now — in every cooperative that distributes ownership, every organization that asks who benefits before it asks what's efficient, every community that practises collective governance, every classroom that reimagines what learning means, every parent who asks not *what will my child do for a living?* but *who will my child become?*

— THE 90% CODE, CONCLUSION: THE PASSAGE

THE 90%
CODE

Developed with the support of AI-assisted design tools.

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